and Kejriwal retains the edge." That said, Deshmukh maintains, "It will not be a one-way traffic for AAP as in the previous two elections."

Meanwhile, CSDS surveys of the past two elections revealed that AAP gets about 68 per cent of the votes of the lower middle and poorer classes, who constitute over 60 per cent of Delhi's 34 million-strong population and are a decisive voting bloc. Kejriwal had carefully built this voter base in the past two terms—a constituency of beneficiaries of government freebies in a city of migrants, cutting across caste and religion. He did this by promising them free power and water supply, free high-quality education in government schools, expansion of hospitals and mohalla clinics, with continued free healthcare for all, free bus travel for women and free pilgrimage trips for the elderly. In all, Kejriwal estimates, each household saves around Rs 25,000 through these schemes. Others contest the figures and put it at around Rs 5,000 per month, but even they admit it is substantial. Prof. Tanvir Aijaz of the political science department in Ramjas College, Delhi, says, "What other political parties call freebies are something that have, at the end of the day, given some savings to the lower middle classes. That's why Kejriwal has that base of supporters. There is no reason for that support base to shift significantly."

To win, Kejriwal must retain his hold over the lower middle class and poorer sections as well as secure the minority votes

THE SHE VOTER

Perhaps the most critical demographic in Kejriwal's electoral calculus are the women voters, who make up nearly 46 per cent of Delhi's electorate. Targeted welfare schemes like free public transport have elicited significant female support for AAP. Ask 34-year-old Nazma Khatoon, one of the many residents of the Chirag Dilli urban village where city dreams meet blue-collar resilience. After Covid-19 claimed her husband's factory job and upended the family finances, Nazma decided she had to step out to work. In this crucible of challenge, the free bus ride became her lifeline. "Eight hundred rupees saved every month," she says. "It's a lot. Why wouldn't we vote for him?"

For Krishna Das, originally from Malda in West Bengal who now works as an office help in Nehru Place, changes in Delhi government schools have brought dignity to her as a parent. "Before Kejriwal, teachers didn't really treat us like parents," she says. "Now I get invited to school to sit with the teacher and get feedback about my son. That's a big deal." For the Lok Sabha election, her vote goes to Modi but it is Kejriwal she has voted for in the past two state elections.

For Election 2025, Kejriwal has doubled the monthly honorarium of Rs 1,000 for every woman above 18 years that he had introduced in last year's Delhi budget to Rs 2,100. Deshmukh says, "While there appears a statistical tie between AAP and BJP for male voters, when it comes to the female voters, AAP is ahead by at least eight percentage points over the BJP. That could prove decisive."

But Kejriwal's bonanza is not restricted to women alone. He is also tapping the young voters by promising free bus travel to all students and 50 per cent concession in metro tickets. For the elderly, he will launch the Sanjeevani Yojana that will ensure free medical services to all citizens above 60 years of age at both government and private hospitals.

Along with these promised benefits, Kejriwal also evokes fear against the BJP in his rallies, saying they will withdraw all welfare measures once they come to power. "If you press the wrong button," he tells the crowd at a well-



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

TRUMP CARD PM Narendra Modi during a BJP rally at Kartar Nagar in Northeast Delhi, Jan. 29

THE BJP OFFENSIVE

The BJP's focus is on Arvind Kejriwal's failures, keeping the cadre rejuvenated and cashing in on the anti-incumbency vote

LABELLING AAP AND KEJRIWAL AS CORRUPT: From calling the party 'AAP-da' (catastrophe) and 'Awaidh Aamdaniwali Party' (party with an illegal income), as well as raking up 'Liquorgate' and 'Sheesh Mahal', the BJP is painting Kejriwal as corrupt and accusing AAP of misgovernance. It is also highlighting specific issues, such as the condition of roads, sewerage, cleaning Yamuna